



Specialized masks connected to oxygen tanks provide oxygen to the mountaineer.

Thin air

At high altitudes, such as on top of mountains, the air is thinner than it is at sea level. This means that the oxygen gas present is more spread out, which makes it difficult to breathe. Mountaineers, therefore, often carry a supply of oxygen in tanks.

Wood needs oxygen to burn, releasing heat and light.

Burning up

When something burns, it is said to be undergoing a reaction called combustion. This process involves three things: oxygen, a fuel (such as wood), and the release of heat (such as fire). If the supply of oxygen is removed, the fire will be extinguished.



Colorful sky

The northern lights—a naturally occurring display of light in some arctic regions—are the result of particles from the sun colliding with gases in Earth's atmosphere. Oxygen and nitrogen in the air are the gases responsible for the dazzling colors. The green color is produced when the sun's particles collide with oxygen, while the blue and violet colors are produced by their collision with nitrogen.



EYEWITNESS

Joseph Priestley

British chemist Joseph Priestley is usually credited with the discovery of oxygen, because he was the first to formally publish his results in 1775. But German-Swedish chemist Carl Wilhelm Scheele also has a claim to this element's discovery as he identified the gas and wrote about it in 1771.

